THE NOISE FLOOR

A short film screenplay

A teenager processes bereavement, silence, and memory six months after a tragic loss.

FADE IN:

INT. DANIEL'S ROOM - AFTERNOON

Late sun filters through light curtains. DANIEL (17) sits at an old desk. In front of him is a portable cassette recorder and three labelled tapes. He presses PLAY on the tape player. SOUND: Magnetic hiss, followed by the clatter of a garage band rehearsal. A teenage voice, MATT (19), laughs near the microphone. MATT'S VOICE (ON TAPE): "Stop recording, Dan, we haven't even tuned the bass yet." Daniel listens, his face completely motionless. He hits PAUSE. The room returns to heavy silence.

INT. KITCHEN - MOMENTS LATER

MOM (48) stands by the stove, stirring soup. She looks tired, carrying a quiet endurance in her posture. Daniel walks in to get a glass of water from the tap.

MOM

Your uncle called earlier. He asked if you wanted to help him in the garden tomorrow.

DANIEL

Maybe next week.

MOM

(softly)

Daniel, you have stayed in your room all morning. It is okay to go outside.

DANIEL

I know.

MOM

I miss him too. Every day. But keeping the door shut doesn't bring him back.

DANIEL

I am not trying to bring him back. I just don't want to forget what his voice sounded like.

Mom pauses her stirring. She turns around to face him. Her eyes are filled with quiet empathy.

MOM

You won't forget. I promise you won't.

INT. DANIEL'S ROOM - EVENING

Daniel sits on the floor near his bed. He holds the small tape player in his lap. He presses REWIND, lets it spin for three seconds, then hits PLAY again. MATT'S VOICE (ON TAPE): "...we haven't even tuned the bass yet." Daniel lets the tape run this time. The background noise continues: ambient guitar strums, footsteps on concrete, casual chatter. Daniel leans his head back against the side of his mattress, closing his eyes, listening to the ordinary, living sound of the past without turning it off.

THE END

FADE OUT.